

The Theology of the Trinity

A Complete Study Developed from *The Oxford Handbook of the Trinity and Companion Sources*

Consolidated edition — Parts I–IV. Prepared 17 July 2026. All quotations are drawn verbatim from the sources held in the source notebook (Emery & Levering, eds., The Oxford Handbook of the Trinity, OUP; V.-M. Kärkkäinen, Christian Understandings of the Trinity; the Cambridge Companion to the Trinity; a Brief History of the Doctrine of the Trinity; J. Moltmann, The Trinity and the Kingdom; and the cited patristic, medieval, and magisterial texts), with the notebook's own internal citations retained.

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Part I: Foundations, History, and Doctrine

Scripture, the patristic and medieval development, the modern renaissance, the heresies, and the magisterium.

1. Foundations in Sacred Scripture

The doctrine of the Trinity is not a biblical formula but the Church's dogmatic articulation of what is given in revelation. As the sources put it, although the word "Trinity" itself never appears in the Bible, "the later development of Trinitarian doctrine relies entirely on the scriptural testimonies of the Old and New Testaments." When "the early church encountered the risen Christ and the Holy Spirit, it was forced to develop a theology that could account for a plurality in unity without violating the uncompromising monotheism inherited from Israel."

1.1 The Old Testament Background

The bedrock of the Old Testament is strict monotheism, encapsulated in the *Shema*: "**Hear, O Israel: The Lord our God, the Lord is one**" (Deuteronomy 6:4). Because of this uncompromising stance, any suggestion of "threeness" could invite suspicion of tritheism. Nevertheless, early Christian theologians — and later modern scholars — recognized in the Old Testament "anticipatory categories and personifications of divine agency that made the later doctrine of the Trinity possible."

- **Plurality in God.** Pre-critical exegesis pointed to the "plurality of majesty" in Genesis 1:26 ("Let us make humankind in our image"), the threefold "Holy, holy, holy" of Isaiah 6:3, and the theophany of the three visitors to Abraham in Genesis 18.
- **Divine agents — Word, Wisdom, Spirit.** The Spirit (*ruach*) is the breath of life sustaining creation (Genesis 1:2; Psalm 104:29–30). God's Word (*dabar*) accomplishes his purposes (Isaiah 55:10–11; Psalm 33:6). Wisdom (*hokmah*) is personified as a pre-existent master worker beside God at creation (Proverbs 8:22–31; Wisdom of Solomon 7:22–26).

Key claim (verbatim): *"The vivid personifications of Wisdom/Word and Spirit, inasmuch as they were both identified with God and the divine activity and distinguished from God, opened up the way toward recognizing God to be tripersonal. The leap from mere personifications to distinct persons is always, to be sure, a giant one. Nevertheless, without these OT personifications (and the Father/Son language applied to God), the acknowledgment of the Trinity would not have been so well and providentially prepared."*

Wolfhart Pannenberg (quoted in the source): *"Christian statements about the Son and Spirit take up questions which had already occupied Jewish thought concerning the essential transcendent reality of the one God and the modes of his manifestation."* The New Testament writers "went beyond the OT faith, no doubt, but not against it, and they could hold on to the *Shema* of Israel while talking about Father, Son, and Spirit as one God."

1.2 The New Testament Witness

The New Testament moves from implicit plurality to the explicit revelation of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. It does not present a systematic doctrine but provides "the most complete set of raw data from which such a doctrine could be constructed."

- **The unique Father–Son relationship.** The foundation is Jesus' intimate address of God as *abba* (Mark 14:36), and the self-distinction of Jesus from the Father coupled with their unity: "**I and the Father are one**" (John 10:30). Stephen Holmes (quoted): the Gospels present "a complex relationship of intimacy, union, shared knowledge and action, and subordination." This is the initial **binitarian** core.
- **The inclusion of the Holy Spirit.** Binitarianism becomes Trinitarianism through the church's experience of the Spirit as "the medium of the communion of Jesus with the Father and the mediator of the participation of believers in Christ." The source summarizes: "*explicit binitarianism and implicit trinitarianism.*"
- **Triadic formulas.** The Great Commission: baptize "**in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit**" (Matthew 28:19). The source stresses: "*the name here is singular even though it has three owners. Neither Father, Son, nor Spirit exhaust the divine identity; rather each shares it.*"

Summary (verbatim): "*The NT statements do not clarify the interrelations of the three but they clearly emphasize the fact that they are interrelated.*"

1.3 The Pauline Literature

Paul's letters are "occasional and pastoral rather than systematic," yet already "thoroughly saturated in a Trinitarian grammar." Paul applies the title *Kyrios* (Lord) — the Greek rendering of *Yahweh* — to the risen Jesus (Romans 10:9; Philippians 2:9–11), "directly including Christ in the identity of the God of Israel."

- **Salvation and reconciliation.** "We have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ" (Romans 5:1) and "God's love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit" (5:5). Galatians 4:4–6: "**God sent forth his Son... God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, 'Abba! Father!'**"
- **Church unity and gifts.** 1 Corinthians 12:4–6: "**same Spirit... same Lord... same God.**" Ephesians 4:4–6: "**one Spirit... one Lord... one God and Father of all.**"
- **Benedictions and liturgy.** 2 Corinthians 13:14: "**The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all.**" Titus 3:4–6 intertwines the saving work of "God our Saviour," the "Holy Spirit," and "Jesus Christ our Saviour."

Summary (verbatim): "*With respect to the view of God found in the Pauline epistles, Trinitarian reflection is the larger theological syntax that illumines and — ultimately — renders intelligible Paul's particular grammatical moves.*"

2. The Patristic Period

2.1 The Apologists and Logos Theology

The second-century Apologists used the concept of the *Logos* (Word/Reason) to explain the Father–Son relationship, drawing on both John's prologue and Hellenistic philosophy. **Justin Martyr**: *"As the beginning before all creatures God begat of himself a certain rational power."* He explained the begetting without division by the analogy of speech: *"when we bring forth a Logos... we beget a Logos without anything being separated from us by this bringing forth, so that the Logos in us is in no way diminished."*

Theophilus of Antioch distinguished the *logos endiathetos* (immanent Word) from the *logos prophorikos* (uttered Word): *"God, having his own Logos innate in his own bowels, generated him together with his own Sophia, vomiting him forth before everything else."* This emission did not deplete the Father: *"He did not deprive himself of the Logos but generated the Logos and constantly converses with his Logos."*

2.2 Tertullian — *una substantia / tres personae*

At the dawn of the third century, **Tertullian** (*Adversus Praxean*) advanced the doctrine to combat modalism and coined the Latin formula **"one substance in three persons"** (**una substantia, tres personae**). His precise statement of distinction-in-unity:

"three, however, not in condition, but in degree; not in substance, but in form; not in power, but in aspect; yet of one substance, and of one condition, and of one power, inasmuch as He is one God, from whom these degrees and forms and aspects are reckoned, under the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost."

And on the real distinction of persons: *"I testify that Father and Son and Spirit are unseparated from one other... Understand then, I say that the Father is one, the Son another, and the Spirit another."* The source notes that Tertullian "is claimed to be the first to apply *persona* and *Trinitas* to the Christian God," where "person" is "the principle of operative individuality."

2.3 Origen — Eternal Generation

The Alexandrian **Origen** made the pioneering assertion of the **eternal generation** of the Son. Because God is immutable, the Father did not become Father in time: *"there was no time at which the Son was not."* He wrote:

"Wherefore we have always held that God is the Father of his only-begotten Son, who was born indeed of him, and derives from him what he is, but without any beginning, not only such as may be measured by any divisions of time, but even that which the mind alone can contemplate within itself."

He compared this timeless begetting to "the begetting of brightness by the light."

2.4 The Arian Controversy

The Alexandrian presbyter **Arius** sought to protect the absolute transcendence of the one God, producing his famous slogan: "**There was a time when he was not.**" Believing God's essence could not be shared or divided, he held the Son to be a creature made from nothing by the Father's will: "*God was not always a Father; once God was alone and not yet a Father, but afterwards he became a Father.*" The Son was therefore "*a perfect creature, yet not among the creatures, a begotten thing, yet not as one among begotten things.*" The source distinguishes Arianism from modalism: "*Where Sabellianism asserted a strict unity of the divine essence without any real distinction of subjects, Arianism distinguished the subjects while denying their unity of essence.*"

2.5 The Council of Nicaea (325) and *homoousios*

To resolve the crisis, the **Council of Nicaea** (325) affirmed the Son as **consubstantial** (***homoousios***) with the Father:

"the only-begotten Son... begotten from the Father, that is from the substance of the Father, God from God, light from light, true God from true God, begotten not made, consubstantial (homoousios) with the Father."

The council appended anathemas directly targeting Arius:

"But for those who say: 'There was a time when he was not;' and 'He was not before he was made;' and 'He was made out of nothing,' or 'He is of another substance' or 'essence,' or 'The Son of God is created,' or 'changeable,' or 'alterable' — they are condemned by the holy catholic and apostolic Church."

The source's verdict: "*Nicaea's main achievement was to place on record once and for all that the being of the Son is identical to the being of the Father, dealing a mortal blow to subordinationism.*"

2.6 Athanasius

Athanasius of Alexandria defended Nicaea on the ground that salvation itself requires the Son to be fully God. On the creating/begetting distinction:

"A work is external to the nature, but a son is the proper offspring of the essence... the Son, not being a work, but proper to the Father's essence, always is; for, whereas the Father always is, so what is proper to his essence must always be."

On the shared substance: *"The whole being of the Son belongs to the Father's substance, as radiance from light, and stream from source; so that he who sees the Son sees what belongs to the Father."* His soteriological axiom: God became man that man might become god-like.

2.7 The Cappadocian Fathers — *one ousia, three hypostases*

Basil the Great, Gregory of Nazianzus, and Gregory of Nyssa provided the terminological breakthrough: **one substance (*mia ousia*) in three persons (*treis hypostaseis*)**. They distinguished terms previously used interchangeably: *"'substance' relates to what is common to Father and Son... whereas 'hypostasis' denotes what is particular to Father and Son, i.e. what makes the Father the Father and the Son the Son."*

Gregory of Nazianzus:

"When I speak of God, you must be illumined at once by one flash of light and by three: three in properties, or hypostases... or persons... but this light is one in respect of the substance, that is, the Godhead."

And: *"To us there is One God, for the Godhead is One... the Godhead is, to speak concisely, undivided in separate Persons; and there is one mingling of Light, as it were of three suns joined to each other."*

2.8 The Council of Constantinople (381) and the Holy Spirit

Nicaea had said little about the Spirit, giving rise to the **Pneumatomachians** ("Spirit-fighters"). Building on the Cappadocians, **Constantinople (381)** affirmed the Spirit's full divinity:

"And in the Holy Spirit, the Lord and life-giver, who proceeds from the Father, who is worshipped and glorified together with the Father and Son, who spoke by the prophets."

The application of *kyrios* to the Spirit and his inclusion in worship "makes a strong statement of the deity of the Spirit." The council avoided *homoousios* for the Spirit "to secure broader consensus," following "the path of St. Basil" in using circumlocutions.

2.9 Augustine's *De Trinitate*

In the Latin West, **Augustine** produced the most influential synthesis, stressing divine simplicity and unity, and the **psychological analogy** of the human mind (memory, understanding, will):

"These three then, memory, understanding, and will, are not three lives but one life, nor three minds but one mind. So it follows of course that they are not three substances but one substance."

On simplicity: *"the Father is light, the Son is light, the Holy Spirit is light; but together they are not three lights but one light. And so the Father is wisdom, the Son is wisdom, the Holy Spirit is wisdom; and together they are not three wisdoms but one wisdom."*

On the Spirit as **mutual love**:

"And therefore there are not more than three; one loving him who is from him, and one loving him from whom he is, and love itself. If this is not anything, how is it that God is love? If it is not substance, how is it that God is substance?"

The Spirit is thus "supreme charity conjoining Father and Son to each other and subjoining us to them." Augustine's analogy, later refined by Aquinas, "served for centuries... as the explication *par excellence* of the mystery of the Trinity."

3. The Medieval and Scholastic Period

3.1 Anselm of Canterbury

Against Roscelin (who reduced the persons to three substances), **Anselm** argued from divine simplicity: *"If the three persons in God are only one thing (res) — and are not three things, each one existing separately in itself (as do three angels or three souls)... then the Father and the Holy Spirit were incarnate with the Son."* On the *Filioque*: the Son and Holy Spirit are *"God from God (Deus de Deo)"* and *"one and the same God with the Father."*

3.2 Richard of St Victor

Richard shifted the focus to the interpersonal dynamics of love: *"charity absolutely cannot exist where a plurality of persons is lacking."* Perfect love must be mutual and, to escape selfishness, requires a third to share it — the *condilectio*:

"What else is intimate and supreme mutual love for a third (condilectio) except the mutual concurrence of intimate benevolence and supreme concord?... just as the virtue of so great a dignity... cannot be lacking in supreme and universally perfect good, so it cannot subsist without a Trinity of persons."

Emphasizing relations of origin over Boethian substance, he redefined person: *"a divine person is an incommunicable existence of the divine nature."*

3.3 Bonaventure

The Franciscan **Bonaventure** centered his theology on the Pseudo-Dionysian self-diffusive Good: *"it pertains to the good to diffuse itself, to share its goodness or perfection with others."* Within the immanent Trinity this is grounded in the Father's *innascibilitas* (unbegottenness) and *fontal plenitude*:

"The Father, however, is innascible, does not arise from another; the Father is of himself. On this basis, the Father enjoys a fundamental primacy... the Father possesses a fontal plenitude."

From this fullness proceed two emanations: the Son *"in the manner of nature (per modum naturae)"*, the Spirit *"per modum voluntatis... a matter of liberality, more of the will."* "The Son is the beloved of the Father, the Holy Spirit the co-beloved of the Father and the Son."

3.4 Thomas Aquinas

Aquinas synthesized Aristotelian metaphysics with Augustinian psychology (*Summa Theologiae* I, qq. 27–43).

- **Processions:** *"We cannot conceive divine processions except as corresponding to actions which remain within the agent. Now in a spiritual and divine nature there are only two such actions, namely to understand and to will."* Thus the Son proceeds by way of intellect (Word), the Spirit by way of will (Love).
- **Subsistent relations:** *"In God, relations are constitutive of the persons. While in creatures relation is an accident, in God relation is taken substantially... since the relations are identical with the divine essence, their being is not accidental. In God, person denotes subsistent relation."*
- **Missions:** a divine mission *"is not essentially different from the eternal procession, but only adds a reference to a temporal effect."* The temporal missions of Son and Spirit are "the outflowing in grace of their eternal procession," drawing the rational creature back into the life of God.

4. The Modern, Twentieth- and Twenty-First-Century Renaissance

4.1 Friedrich Schleiermacher

In the wake of the Enlightenment, Schleiermacher marginalized the doctrine, relegating it to the conclusion of his system: the doctrine of the triune God is *"not a direct statement about Christian self-consciousness, but only a web of several such statements"* (*The Christian Faith*, §170). He held that "we have no formula for the being of God in Himself as distinct from the being of God in the world."

4.2 Karl Barth

Barth ignited the twentieth-century renaissance, front-loading the doctrine at the head of the *Church Dogmatics*: *"The doctrine of the Trinity is what basically distinguishes the Christian doctrine of God as Christian, and therefore what already distinguishes the Christian concept of revelation as Christian, in contrast to all other possible doctrines of God and concepts of revelation"* (CD I/1, 301). The Trinity is the very logic of revelation: *"God reveals Himself. He reveals Himself through Himself. He reveals Himself"* — correlated to Revealer (Father), Revelation (Son), Revealedness (Spirit): *"God in unimpaired unity yet also in unimpaired distinction is Revealer, Revelation, and Revealedness."*

4.3 Karl Rahner

Rahner rescued the doctrine from speculative isolation with his identity axiom (**Rahner's Rule**): **"The 'economic' Trinity is the 'immanent' Trinity and the 'immanent' Trinity is the 'economic' Trinity"** (*The Trinity*, 22). It follows that human beings do not experience an undifferentiated essence: *"Each one of the three divine persons communicates himself to man in gratuitous grace in his own personal particularity and diversity."*

4.4 Jürgen Moltmann

Moltmann pushed Trinitarian theology toward the cross and social ethics, critiquing divine impassibility: *"A God who cannot suffer is poorer than any man. For a God who is incapable of suffering is a being who cannot be involved... But the one who cannot suffer cannot love either. So he is also a loveless being."* The cross as an intra-Trinitarian event:

"What happened on the cross was an event between God and God. It was a deep division in God himself, in so far as God abandoned God and contradicted himself, and at the same time a unity in God, in so far as God was at one with God and corresponded to himself."

4.5 Hans Urs von Balthasar

Von Balthasar traced the cross back to an eternal *kenosis* in the immanent Trinity. In Karen Kilby's summary: *"the Father strips himself, without remainder, of his Godhead and hands it over to the Son."* The cross draws forsakenness into God: *"the Son's God-forsakenness is drawn into the love relationship within the Trinity (die Einbeziehung der Gottverlassenheit in die trinitarische Liebesbeziehung). The Son takes the estrangement into himself and creates proximity."*

4.6 John Zizioulas

The Orthodox theologian argued that the Cappadocians revolutionized ontology: *"Being means life, and life means communion."* Grounding God's being in the Person of the Father secures divine freedom:

"God, as Father and not as substance, perpetually confirms through 'being' His free will to exist... the Father out of love — that is, freely — begets the Son and brings forth the Spirit."

4.7 Catherine Mowry LaCugna

Building on Zizioulas, LaCugna argued that separating God's inner life (*theologia*) from God's saving action (*oikonomia*) caused the "defeat" of the doctrine, producing *"a one-sided theology that had little to do with the economy of Christ and the Spirit... and therefore little to do with Christian life."* The doctrine is the *"sine qua non for preserving the essential relational character of God, the relational character of human existence and the interdependent quality of the entire universe."*

4.8 The Latin vs. Social Trinity Debate

A defining late-twentieth-century debate. Moltmann summarizes the divide:

"Two different categories of analogy have always been used for the eternal life of the Trinity: the category of the individual person, and the category of community. Ever since Augustine's development of the psychological doctrine of the Trinity, the first has taken precedence in the West; whereas the Cappadocian Fathers and the Orthodox theologians, down to the present day, employ the second category. They incline towards an emphatically social doctrine of the Trinity and criticize the modalistic tendencies in the 'personal' trinitarian doctrine of the Western church."

Social Trinitarians warn that beginning from a single divine subject yields a problematic "monarchical monotheism"; the alternative locates "relationships and communities" at the core of the divine life. (Critics such as Karen Kilby caution that social Trinitarianism can project a preferred human community back onto God.)

5. Heresies, Controversies, and the *Filioque*

5.1 Modalism / Sabellianism

To protect the unity and monarchy of God, Sabellius, Noetus, and Praxeas denied real eternal distinctions, treating "Father," "Son," and "Spirit" as modes of one God. The fatal consequence was **patripassianism** — that the Father himself suffered and died. Refuted by Tertullian, Hippolytus, and Novatian, and definitively by the Cappadocian *ousia/hypostasis* distinction.

5.2 Subordinationism

A pervasive pre-Nicene tendency (Justin, Irenaeus, Origen) that ranked Son and Spirit ontologically below the Father under the influence of Middle-Platonic *Logos* philosophy. Answered by Nicaea's *homoousios* and by Cappadocian apophaticism: the infinite divine nature admits no degrees of "more or less," so the persons are coequal, distinguished only by relations of origin.

5.3 Arianism

Arius radicalized subordinationism: the Son a creature from nothing, "there was a time when he was not," subject to change. Disastrous soteriologically, since "a mere creature was mediating salvation." Condemned at Nicaea (325); Athanasius argued that only if the Son is fully God can he divinize humanity.

5.4 Pneumatomachianism / Macedonianism

The "Spirit-fighters" accepted the Son's divinity but denied the Spirit's, making him a creature or impersonal power. Athanasius and Basil replied that the Spirit sanctifies and gives divine life in baptism — which no creature can do. Resolved at Constantinople I (381).

5.5 Tritheism

Belief in three gods, arising when the persons are overemphasized as independent centres. The sixth-century Monophysite John Philoponus fell into it by applying Aristotle's "first substances" to the Trinity. Guarded against by the unity of essence, the "monarchy of the Father," *perichoresis* (mutual indwelling), the rule that all external operations (*ad extra*) are undivided, and — in the West — Aquinas' subsistent relations.

5.6 The Filioque Controversy

The Western church added *Filioque* ("and the Son") to the Creed (Spain, c. 589), teaching that the Spirit proceeds from the Father *and the Son*, to safeguard the Son's consubstantiality. The East objected on two grounds: (1) it was a unilateral addition made without an ecumenical council; and (2) it threatened the "monarchy of the Father," seeming to introduce two sources into the Godhead.

Resolution (verbatim): *"Historically, it was not resolved; it became the primary theological catalyst for the Great Schism of 1054."* Reunion attempts at Lyons (1274) and Florence (1439) failed to last. Modern dialogue treats the Greek and Latin traditions as complementary: the Father alone is the "principle without principle," and the Eastern formula that the Spirit proceeds from the Father *through* the Son is recognized as a valid expression of the same mystery.

6. Magisterium: Councils, Creeds, Vatican II, and the Popes

6.1 The Early Ecumenical Councils and Creeds

- **Nicaea (325):** secured the Son's divinity with *homoousios*: "of one substance... consubstantial with the Father." Source: "Nicaea's main achievement was to place on record once and for all that the being of the Son is identical to the being of the Father."
- **Constantinople I (381):** confessed the Spirit as "the Lord and Giver of life, who proceeds from the Father, who together with the Father and the Son is worshiped and glorified." The resulting Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed "became the sole baptismal confession of the East and the Eucharistic creed of all Christians."

6.2 Medieval Councils

- **Fourth Lateran Council (1215):** against Joachim of Fiore — *"Each of the persons is that supreme reality, viz., the divine substance, essence or nature."* Its hermeneutical rule: *"For between creator and creature there can be noted no likeness (similitudo) so great that a greater dissimilarity (dissimilitudo) cannot be seen between them."*
- **Council of Florence (1438–45):** on the procession — *"the Holy Spirit proceeds eternally from the Father and the Son, not as from two principles, but as from one principle; not by two spirations, but by one single spiration."* On unity: in God "everything is one where the difference of a relation does not prevent this."
- **Council of Trent (1545–63):** since the Reformers retained the classical Trinity, Trent "contents itself with a simple statement of the reality of the Holy Spirit within us."

6.3 Papal and Magisterial Documents

- **Leo XIII**, *Divinum illud munus* (1897): the mystery of the Trinity is "the substance of the New Testament."
- **Pius XII**, *Mystici Corporis* (1943): teaches "the divine missions, the indwelling of the Trinity and the gifts of the Holy Ghost" — *"By grace God dwells in the just soul as in a temple... the divine indwelling."*
- **Catechism of the Catholic Church**: *"The Trinity is One. We do not confess three Gods, but one God in three persons, the 'consubstantial Trinity.'"* And: *"The divine persons are really distinct from one another. God is one but not solitary... 'It is the Father who generates, the Son who is begotten, and the Holy Spirit who proceeds.'"*
- **Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith (2001, on Jacques Dupuis)**: rejected any implication of "separation between the Word and Jesus, or between the Word's salvific activity and that of Jesus," or that "the salvific action of the Holy Spirit extends beyond the one universal salvific economy of the Incarnate Word."

6.4 Second Vatican Council

- ***Lumen Gentium (§2, §4)**: *the Church is "a people made one with the unity of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit."** The CDF later noted this implies "the actions of Christ and of the Spirit are 'co-ordinated.'"
- ***Unitatis Redintegratio (Decree on Ecumenism)**: *Christian unity "finds its highest model and source in the unity of the persons of the Trinity: the unity of the one God, the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit."**

7. Enduring Problems and Study Guide

7.1 Enduring Problems in Tension

32. **Threeness–oneness balance** — avoiding both modalism (too much oneness) and tritheism (too much threeness).
33. **The meaning of "person"** — *hypostasis / prosopon / persona* against the modern psychological "person" (flagged by both Barth and Rahner as misleading).
34. **The *Filioque*** — still church-dividing between East and West, though softened in modern dialogue.
35. **Immanent vs. economic Trinity** — how God-in-himself relates to God-for-us (Rahner's axiom and its limits).
36. **Divine impassibility** — whether there is suffering, event, or history "in" God (Moltmann and von Balthasar vs. classical theism).
37. **Projection** — whether the social Trinity reads human politics back into God (Kilby's critique).

7.2 Recommended Study Materials by Level

Introductory

- *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, §§232–267 — the magisterial baseline.
- Gerald O'Collins, *The Tripersonal God* — clear Catholic survey.

- Anne Hunt, *The Trinity: Insights from the Mystics*.

Intermediate

- Gilles Emery, O.P., *The Trinity: An Introduction to Catholic Doctrine on the Triune God* — the best Thomistic-Catholic textbook.
- Catherine Mowry LaCugna, *God for Us* — the modern "practical Trinity."
- V.-M. Kärkkäinen, *Christian Understandings of the Trinity* — historical-global survey (in the notebook).

Advanced / Scholarly

- Gilles Emery & Matthew Levering (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of the Trinity* (OUP) — the principal reference (this notebook's core source).
- Lewis Ayres, *Nicaea and Its Legacy*; Khaled Anatolios, *Retrieving Nicaea*.
- Karl Rahner, *The Trinity*; Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics* I/1; Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* I, qq. 27–43; John Zizioulas, *Being as Communion*; Jürgen Moltmann, *The Trinity and the Kingdom*.

Part II: Primary Sources and Systematic Themes

The creeds and conciliar definitions in full, perichoresis, appropriations and missions, pneumatology, the answer to tritheism, deification, and the Eastern approach.

1. The Creeds and Conciliar Definitions (verbatim)

1.1 The Creed of Nicaea (325), with Anathemas

"We believe in One God Father, Almighty, the Maker of all things visible and invisible. And in One Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, begotten from the Father, Only-begotten, that is from the substance of the Father; God from God, Light from Light, true God from true God, begotten not made, consubstantial with the Father, by whom all things were made, both things in heaven and things on earth; who for us men and for our salvation came down and was incarnate, was made man, suffered, and rose again the third day, ascended into heaven, and is coming to judge living and dead. And in the Holy Spirit.

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And those who say 'There once was when He was not' and 'Before being begotten He was not,' and 'He came into being out of nothing,' or those who pretend that the Son of God is 'from another hypostasis or substance', or 'created', or 'alterable', or 'mutable', the Catholic and Apostolic Church anathematizes."

1.2 The Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed (381)

"We believe in one God Father, Almighty, the Maker of heaven and earth, and of all things visible and invisible. And in one Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, only-begotten from the Father before all ages; Light from Light, true God from true God; begotten, not made, consubstantial with the Father; by whom all things were made. Who, for us men and for our salvation, came down from heaven, and became incarnate by the Holy Spirit and the virgin Mary, and was made man; was crucified also for us under Pontius Pilate; and suffered, and was buried; and the third day rose again, according to the Scriptures; and ascended into heaven, and is seated at the right hand of the Father; and will come again with glory to judge the living and the dead; whose kingdom will have no end. And in the Holy Spirit, the Lord and Giver of Life; who proceeds from the Father; who together with the Father and the Son is worshipped and glorified; who spoke through the prophets. In one holy, catholic, and apostolic

church. We confess one baptism for the remission of sins. We look for the resurrection of the dead, and the life of the coming age. Amen."

1.3 The Athanasian Creed (*Quicumque vult*) — excerpts

The sources do not contain the full uninterrupted text, but preserve these verbatim excerpts:

- "The Father has neither been made by anyone, nor is he created or begotten (*a nullo*); the Son is from the Father alone (*a Patre solo est*), not made nor created but begotten; the Holy Spirit is from the Father and the Son (*a Patre et Filio*), not made nor created nor begotten, but proceeding."
- "the Father is God, the Son is God, and the Holy Spirit is God; and yet there are not three Gods, but one God."
- "the Father is eternal, the Son is eternal, the Holy Spirit is eternal," and yet "there are not three eternals but one eternal."
- "the Father is omnipotent, the Son is omnipotent, the Holy Spirit is omnipotent," and yet "there are not three omnipotents but only one omnipotent."
- "The person of the Father is other than that of the Son and that of the Holy Ghost."
- "Unity is to be worshiped in trinity and trinity in unity."

1.4 The Eleventh Council of Toledo (675)

"In the relational names of the persons the Father is related to the Son, the Son to the Father, and the Holy Spirit to both. While they are called three persons in view of their relations, we believe in one nature or substance."

*"it must be held that the Son was created, neither out of nothingness nor yet out of any substance, but that He was begotten or born out of the Father's womb (*de utero Patris*), that is, out of his very essence."*

1.5 The Fourth Lateran Council (1215)

"[The divine nature] is not the one begetting or the one begotten or the one proceeding, but it is the Father who begets, the Son who is begotten, and the Holy Ghost proceeds, in order that there may be distinctions in the Persons and unity in the nature."

"Each of the persons is that supreme reality, viz., the divine substance, essence or nature."

The council's hermeneutical rule (from the companion study): "For between creator and creature there can be noted no likeness (similitudo) so great that a greater dissimilarity (dissimilitudo) cannot be seen between them."

1.6 The Council of Florence (1439–42)

"These three persons are one God, not three Gods, because there is one substance of the three, one essence, one nature, one Godhead, one immensity, one eternity, and everything is one where the opposition of a relation does not prevent this."

"the Father is whole in the Son, whole in the Holy Spirit; the Son is whole in the Father, whole in the Holy Spirit; the Holy Spirit is whole in the Father, whole in the Son."

"The Holy Spirit proceeds from both (the Father and the Son) eternally as from one principle and by one single spiration."

2. Perichoresis — Mutual Indwelling

Perichoresis denotes "the reciprocal interiority of the trinitarian persons," their "co-inherence in one another without any coalescence or commixture." Literally "dancing around," it names "the radical, loving interconnectedness (*circumincessio*) of the three divine persons... their *perichoresis*, or reciprocal presence and interpenetration."

John of Damascus gave the doctrine its classic form: "The most original contributions of John to the doctrine of the Trinity are to be found in his notion of coinherence, περιχώρησις." He held that "the persons of the Trinity are wholly 'in one another'"; unlike human beings (whose common humanity is conceptual and individual separation real), for the Trinity "their distinct individuality is conceptual, in reality there is no separate individuality, but a complete coinherence between the persons of the Trinity." He uses it to deny both tritheism and modalism:

"Therefore we name not three gods the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit, but rather one God, the Holy Trinity, for Son and Spirit lead back to one principle, they are not put together or melt together, as Sabellius would have it (for they are unified... not in that they mix together, but in that they adhere to one another, and have the state of being in one another (έν ἀλλήλοις περιχώρησιν) without any mixture or amalgamation)." (De fide Orthodoxa I.8)

Aquinas grounded co-inherence in three ways — essence, relation, and origin: the Father exists in the Son by communicating the whole essence; the persons are "mutually constituting

opposites"; and the procession of the Word is immanent, "within, not outside, the speaker of the word" (ST I, q. 42, a. 5).

Modern retrieval. "Contemporary trinitarian theology is fond of the idea of *perichōrēsis*." **Barth:** *perichōrēsis* is "shorthand for the 'dialectical union and distinction' of the one God who in intimate communion is irreducibly three" (CD I/1, 369). **Moltmann** leans on John Damascene: the concept "grasps the circulatory character of the eternal divine life... In the perichoresis, the very thing that divides them becomes that which binds them together," and: "The doctrine of the perichoresis links together in a brilliant way the threeness and the unity, without reducing the threeness to the unity, or dissolving the unity in the threeness... through the concept of perichoresis, all subordinationism in the doctrine of the Trinity is avoided." In these models the relations are "not marked by a linear and hierarchical descent but by a circular and inclusive movement or dance (*perichōrēsis*)."

3. Appropriations, the Undivided External Works, and the Missions

3.1 The Doctrine of Appropriations

Appropriation is the procedure "by which a reality common to the three persons... is attributed in a special way to a divine person," to help the human mind perceive the distinct properties of the persons. **Aquinas:**

"Now these three things, namely, power, wisdom and goodness, are common to the three persons... the power, which involves the notion of principle, is appropriated to the Father, who is the principle of the entire Godhead; wisdom to the Son, who proceeds as Word, which is nothing else than wisdom begotten; goodness is appropriated to the Holy Spirit, who proceeds as love, whose object is goodness. Therefore, by appropriation we can say: from him, namely from the Father, through him, namely through the Son, in him, namely in the Holy Spirit, are all things."

3.2 Opera Trinitatis ad extra indivisa sunt

The axiom: any action God performs outside the divine life is executed by the whole Trinity acting as one. The distinction of eternal relations is preserved *ad intra*, while the works *ad extra* are undivided (a rule "also affirmed by Greek theologians (clearly formulated by Gregory of Nyssa)"). **Augustine:**

"the Father, and the Son, and the Holy Spirit, as they are indivisible, so work indivisibly."

"the Trinity is proposed to our belief and believed... as so inseparable that whatever action is performed by it must be thought to be performed at the same time by the Father and by the Son and by the Holy Spirit."

3.3 Processions and Missions

- **Processions** are the eternal internal origins (*ad intra*): the generation of the Son and the spiration of the Spirit; immanent, constituting the persons.
- **Missions** are the temporal sending (*ad extra*) of a divine person into the world or into the souls of the just.

The temporal missions are the historical prolongations of the eternal processions. **Augustine**:

"Just as 'to be born' is for the Son 'to be from the Father,' so 'to be sent' is for the Son 'to be known that He is from another.' And as 'to be the gift of God' is for the Holy Spirit 'to proceed from the Father,' so 'to be sent' is 'to be known that He proceeds from Him.'"

Aquinas: the mission implies no change in God, only a new effect in the creature — "The temporal procession is not essentially different from the eternal procession, but only adds a reference to a temporal effect"; the mission is the eternal relation "represented in the soul by some similitude received."

4. Pneumatology — the Person and Divinity of the Holy Spirit

4.1 Basil of Caesarea, *On the Holy Spirit* (c. 375)

Written against the *Pneumatomachi*, Basil "does not forthrightly call the Spirit 'God' or use the controversial term *homoousios*," defending the Spirit's divinity through his co-equal works, equality of honour (*homotimia*), and shared attributes:

- "He is named Spirit: 'God is Spirit'... He is called holy, as the Father is holy and the Son is holy. For creatures, holiness comes from without; for the Spirit, holiness fills His very nature."
- "He is not sanctified, but sanctifies. He is called good, as the Father is good; the essence of the Spirit embraces the goodness of the Father."
- The Spirit is "by nature divine."

4.2 The Procession of the Spirit

Scripture says the Spirit "proceeds" from the Father (John 15:26), distinguishing procession from the Son's begetting. The East treats the difference with apophatic reserve — **John of Damascus**: "We have learned that there is a difference between begetting and procession, but what the manner of this difference is we have not learned at all." **Photius** (defending procession from the Father alone): "the Holy Spirit is proclaimed by theology to proceed from the same and only cause."

The West (**Aquinas**) distinguishes the two processions by intellect and will:

"The procession of love in God ought not to be called 'generation'... the procession which corresponds to the nature of the intellect carries with it

the idea of likeness... However the procession which corresponds to the will's action is not envisaged in terms of likeness, but rather of urge and motion towards something. And thus what proceeds in God as love does not proceed as begotten or son, but rather as a breathing of spirit."

4.3 The Spirit as Gift and Love

Augustine:

- "in that simple and highest nature, substance is not one thing, and love another, but that substance itself is love, and that love itself is substance... and yet the Holy Spirit is properly called love."
- "So the love which is from God and is God is distinctively the Holy Spirit; through him the charity of God is poured out in our hearts, and through it the whole Trinity dwells in us. This is the reason why it is most apposite that the Holy Spirit, while being God, should also be called the gift of God."
- "He is given as God's gift in such a way that as God he also gives himself."

Aquinas:

"A gift in the proper sense is something gratuitously given without the expectation of a return. The reason for gratuitous donation is love... Since the Holy Spirit proceeds as Love, he is also the first gift... Gift, therefore, is also the proper name of the Holy Spirit, as is Love." (ST I, q. 38, a. 2)

5. Gregory of Nyssa's *Ad Ablabium* and the Answer to Tritheism

Ablabius posed the dilemma: if "Peter, James, and John, being in one human nature, are called three men," why not call Father, Son, and Spirit three Gods? Gregory answered with two arguments.

1. The indivisibility of nature (universals). Natures are "in fact indivisible, although we often speak lazily as if they could be divided." As Mark Edwards summarizes: "just as the three who are God make one God in the aggregate and not three, so three representatives of humanity constitute man and not three men. The use of the plural 'men' in the Scriptures is thus... a condescension to the vulgar idiom, not... a lesson in grammar to the theologian." Pluralizing "God" is an illegitimate grammatical error.

2. The unity of operations. "the word 'Godhead' is not significant of nature but of operation." Where humans share a nature yet act independently, in God there is no independent action:

"But in the case of the Divine nature we do not similarly learn that the Father does anything by Himself in which the Son does not work conjointly... but every operation which extends from God to the Creation..."

has its origin from the Father, and proceeds through the Son, and is perfected in the Holy Spirit."

The Cappadocian solution. "All things issue from the will of the Father, are actualized by the Son, and brought to perfection by the Spirit." The persons are one God by single will and power, yet distinguished by eternal relations of origin — "The Father is ingenerate, the Son begotten, the Spirit spirated" — real and eternal distinctions ("modes of God's being"), not merely Sabellian "modes of God's self-revelation."

6. The Trinity and Christian Life — Deification, Indwelling, Doxology

Deification (*theosis*). **Athanasius:** "For he became man that we might become divine; and he revealed himself through a body that we might receive an idea of the invisible Father."

Divinization is by grace, not nature. **Augustine:** "they are deified by his grace, not born of his substance... If we have been made sons of God, we have also been made gods: but this is the effect of grace adopting, not of nature generating." The Creator–creature distinction remains intact: "Ours is a 'participation' in the divine nature, but this participation is dependent on the utter difference between Creator and creature remaining intact."

The indwelling of the Trinity. Grace is the substantial presence of the whole Triune God in the believer. **Aquinas:** "since we are made lovers of God by the Holy Spirit, and every beloved is in the lover as such, by the Holy Spirit necessarily the Father and the Son dwell in us also."

Bonaventure: "The whole Trinity comes anew to dwell within the sinner, when grace is given to him." **Augustine:** "God dwells in his temple: not the Holy Spirit alone, but also the Father and the Son." Sanctifying grace makes the believer "capable of God by knowledge and love."

Practical and doxological significance. **LaCugna:** "the doctrine of the Trinity is not ultimately a teaching about God but a teaching about God's life with us and our life with each other"; "living as persons in communion, in right relationship is the *meaning of salvation*." **Moltmann:** "Real theology... finds expression in thanks, praise and adoration... Here we know only in so far as we love. Here we know in order to participate. Then to know God means to participate in the fullness of the divine life." "Before being the object of a doctrinal reflection, the Trinity causes faith, thanksgiving, and the believers' praise of God."

7. Contemporary, Analytic, Feminist, and Interreligious Trinitarian Theology

Analytic theology favours "clarity, rigour, and brevity," addressing the one-and-three problem "by breaking it up into parts... what we mean by such concepts as 'nature', 'person', 'relation'."

Thomas McCall maps three approaches: "'social Trinitarianism', developed first by Cornelius Plantinga and Richard Swinburne; 'relative identity', developed primarily by Michael Rea; and 'Latin trinitarianism', most fully defended by Brian Leftow." Critics warn of "tritheism" and "cognitional positivism" (Surin), and — **Stephen Holmes** — that "language refers univocally to the divine and the created" without raising analogy.

Feminist theology. **Elizabeth Johnson** targets "speech about God in metaphors that are exclusively, literally, and patriarchally male," renaming the persons "Spirit-Sophia, Jesus-Sophia, and Mother-Sophia," glossing the divine name as "SHE WHO IS," and proposing "Suffering God: Compassion Poured Out." "God's being is identical with an act of communion." **Miroslav Volf** faults Sallie McFague's "Mother, Lover, and Friend" as ending "in modalism... a relationally impoverished monism." **Sarah Coakley** approaches the Trinity through prayer as "an irreducible threeness that always refuses a mere mutuality of two." **Nonna Verna Harrison** (Orthodox) resists replacing the scriptural names: "divine paternity does not mean that the immaterial Father is male."

Theology of religions. **Raimon Panikkar** proposes a "cosmotheandric reality," aligning apophatic Buddhism with the Father, personalist theism with the Son, and Advaitic immanence with the Spirit. **Gavin D'Costa** praises the erudition but warns "the symbolic triadic structure subordinates the historical particular narrative of revelation," preferring to read such resonances as *vestigia Trinitatis*. Against pluralists (Hick), D'Costa: "The Trinitarian theology of Christianity helps to explain why the presence of God's Spirit in other religions is the presence of Christ," and a Trinitarian approach "actually attains pluralist goals... in taking difference and otherness utterly seriously."

8. The Eastern Orthodox / Greek Patristic Approach

The monarchy of the Father. The unity of God is grounded not in a shared impersonal essence but in the person of the Father, sole source (*archē*) and cause (*aitia*). **Zizioulas**: "God, as Father and not as substance, perpetually confirms through 'being' His free will to exist... the Father out of love — that is, freely — begets the Son and brings forth the Spirit... God as person — as the hypostasis of the Father — makes the one divine substance to be that which it is: the one God." **Gregory of Nazianzus**: "The three have one nature... the ground of unity being the Father, out of whom and toward whom the subsequent persons are reckoned."

The essence—energies distinction (Gregory Palamas). To hold together transcendence and real participation (*theosis*), the East distinguishes God's unknowable essence from his uncreated energies. **Lossky**: "the essence of God, or His nature... which is inaccessible, unknowable, and incommunicable; and the energies or divine operations... in which He goes forth from Himself, manifests, communicates, and gives Himself." "God's essence is unknowable; creation is deified through participation in God's energies."

Contrast with the Latin West. "in general, Greek theology emphasizes the divine hypostases (persons), whereas Latin theology emphasizes the divine nature" — though the sources note this East-begins-with-threeness / West-with-oneness contrast "is also a caricature" now doubted by many scholars. On the *Filioque*, **Photius**: the Spirit proceeds "from the Father alone (ἐκ μόνου τοῦ πατρὸς)... from the same and only cause." **Lossky**: the monarchy of the Father "guards against the *Filioque*," and "by the dogma of the *Filioque*, the God of the philosophers and savants is introduced into the heart of the Living God." On grace, the East insists on participation in the uncreated energies against Western "created grace."

Part III: Later Eras and Disputed Questions

The Reformation and anti-Trinitarianism, later-medieval scholasticism, vestigia Trinitatis, German Idealism, the de Regnon debate, twentieth-century systematics, Christology, and worship.

1. The Reformation and Anti-Trinitarianism

The Reformers shifted Trinitarian theology "from scholastic, metaphysical speculation to a more pastoral and soteriological framework centered on the 'economy of salvation.'" "Neither Calvin nor Luther, by virtue of their fundamentally biblical orientation... engaged in the scholastic method."

Martin Luther integrated the Trinity with his theology of the cross and of self-giving love:

"These are the three persons and one God, who has given himself to us all wholly and completely, with all that he is and has. The Father gives himself... the Son himself subsequently gave himself... the Holy Spirit comes and gives himself to us also."

Christ is the sole access to God — he "unguardedly overstates: 'Apart from Christ, there is no God.'" On terminology, Luther held that "Our adversaries... are fanatics about words, because they want us to demonstrate the truth of the trinitarian article... by asking us to assent to the term *homoousios*" — for him "the *res* has priority over its corresponding *verbum*."

John Calvin gave "a biblically based exposition that largely avoids philosophical terminologies," quoting Gregory of Nazianus: "I cannot think of the unity without being irradiated by the Trinity: I cannot distinguish between the Trinity without being carried up to the unity." Against Servetus and Gentile he developed the **Son as *autotheos** ("*God of himself*"): "*preserving the full deity of the Son requires us to confess that he is autotheos*, God of himself.*" The nuance: "the fact that the Son is 'God of himself' reflects a truth about his consubstantial divine essence... whereas the fact that he is 'begotten of the Father' reflects a truth about his unique divine personhood." "Calvin holds that the Son has his divinity from himself, just as the Father does."

The Council of Trent stayed sober on the mystery of indwelling: "the Council of Trent contents itself with a simple statement of the reality of the Holy Spirit within us."

Anti-Trinitarianism. *Sola scriptura* gave rise to "biblical anti-trinitarianism."

- **Michael Servetus** (executed at Geneva) "was absolutely committed to the authority of Scripture, but regarded the doctrine of the Trinity to be a later distortion of biblical truth, rooted in Greek philosophy rather than in the Scriptures."
- **The Socinians** — Faustus Socinus: "the existence of three persons in one nature was contradictory"; to "safeguard the unity and oneness of God" they held "Jesus's deity is not

affirmed but, rather, his humanity." The *Racovian Catechism* (1605) taught "that God is unipersonal... since a person is 'an individual intelligent essence.'"

- **Early Unitarianism** merged biblical skepticism with Enlightenment rationalism.

2. Later-Medieval Scholasticism — Lombard, Scotus, Ockham

Peter Lombard's **Sentences** became the standard medieval textbook, its first book treating "God one and triune... the processions of the Son then of the Holy Spirit." Joachim of Fiore attacked Lombard for holding that "neither has the Father engendered the divine substance, nor has the divine essence engendered the Son," alleging a "quaternity"; but Lombard so wrote "in order to avoid coming to the conclusion that the Father engendered himself," and "Against Joachim's charges, the fourth Lateran Council in 1215 proclaimed the orthodoxy of the Lombard." His identification of "charity and the Holy Spirit" was later set aside though never condemned.

John Duns Scotus (d. 1308) made "a near total rejection of the relation account": "the persons were absolutes, constituted by absolute origin," and "the constitutive... feature of each produced person is the very production of that person, and this production has no quiddity or nature of its own." He relied on the first/second-substance distinction — "the divine essence is a nature or a quiddity (i.e. a second substance)... the divine person is first substance or individual suppositum" — and introduced the **formal distinction**: "a distinction in something prior to any act of the intellect, yet less than a fully real distinction," by which "intellect and will are formally distinct both from each other and from the divine essence." He used it to defuse the expository syllogism: "there is nevertheless a formal distinction between them — the Father is not purely or absolutely identical with the essence."

William of Ockham (1280–1349), fideist and nominalist, "postulated that the doctrine could be believed only by the authority of the church." Nominalism sharpened the problem: "if one retains the concept of a substance that unites the three persons, then it represents a fourth entity... If, however, the three persons are not united by one substance, then they constitute three distinct and separate entities, thus representing tritheism." Yet "although William of Ockham thought Scotus' formal distinction to be unintelligible, nevertheless he accepted that person and essence are formally distinct precisely because he could see no other way to guarantee the universality of Aristotelian logic."

3. *Vestigia Trinitatis*, Analogy, and Natural Knowledge of the Trinity

Trinity and creation. **Irenaeus** rejected intermediaries with the "two hands" image: "For with him were always present the Word and Wisdom, the Son and the Spirit by whom and in whom, freely, he made all things." **Aquinas**: "God the Father made the creature through his Word, which is the Son, and through his love, which is the Holy Spirit... processions of the persons are the *rationes* for the production of creatures." **Moltmann** goes further: "creation is actually a product of the Father's love and is ascribed to the whole Trinity... He creates out of the powers and energies of his own Spirit."

Vestigia Trinitatis. Augustine (on Rom 1:20): "When therefore we regard the Creator, who is understood by the things that are made we must needs understand the Trinity of whom there appear traces in the creature, as is fitting." **Bonaventure**: "The created world is like a book in which its Maker, the trinity, shines forth... as a vestige, as an image, and as a similitude." **Hugh of St Victor** correlated power/wisdom/goodness with immensity/beauty/utility. **Aquinas**: "all creatures bear a trace of the Trinity (*vestigium Trinitatis*)... as (i) a subsisting, existing thing having (ii) definite form and intelligibility and (iii) as being inclined, ordered or related to another as its end."

Analogy and its limits. Augustine used the psychological analogies (memory/understanding/will; lover/beloved/love) "not to derive the trinity from the unity but to simply illustrate the Trinity in whom one already believes," insisting "If you understand, it is not God." Volf: "Our notions of the triune God are not the triune God."

Natural knowledge. Richard of St Victor was optimistic ("there is no lack of not merely plausible but even irrefutable arguments for any truth"). **Aquinas** set the standard boundary: "It is impossible to come to the knowledge of the Trinity of divine persons through natural reason... through natural reason we can know what has to do with the unity of nature, but not with the distinction of persons." Worse, "He who tries to prove the trinity of persons by natural powers of reason detracts from faith in two ways"; analogies show only *fittingness*: "granted that one accepts the Trinity there are certain confirmations from the fittingness of things, yet not so much as may prove the Trinity of persons conclusively."

4. The Trinity in German Idealism and the Nineteenth Century

Kant judged the Trinity "a mystery surpassing all human concepts"; Schleiermacher relegated it to an appendix. German Idealism instead brought "to the centre of philosophy the idea of a triadic dynamic encompassing all of reality."

Hegel made the Trinity the supreme symbol of his system: "the unfolding of the history of the world... is but the process of the Spirit, ultimately the Spirit becoming conscious of itself."

Moltmann: "Ever since Hegel in particular, the Christian Trinity has tended to be represented in terms belonging to the general concept of the absolute subject: one subject — three modes of being... an eternal process of self-differentiation and self-identification of the absolute subject."

Hegel mapped the dialectic onto the economy: "The Father creates that which is not-God; the Son becomes that which is not-God and embraces total otherness from the Father — death — to bring about reconciliation, the Spirit-filled eschaton." But he "rejects a tri-personal divinity in favour of a self-realizing triadic dynamic," the persons becoming "vanishing moments."

Substantively the grounding reverses: "It is the economy... that retrospectively gives authentic reality to the immanent sphere."

Influence. Hegel's reading "freed nineteenth-century theology from the exegetical preoccupations of eighteenth-century theology." Dorner "viewed God as a harmony of opposites"; von Hofmann: "In eternity, God determined to become Father, Son, and Spirit for

the sake of this history." Moltmann charges that transferring subjectivity to the one essence in Barth and Rahner ("one divine subject in three... modes of being") is "a late triumph for the Sabellian modalism." Moltmann and Pannenberg both "expressed their debt to Hegel."

5. The Historiographical Turn — the "de Régnon Paradigm" and its Critics

The paradigm, from the Jesuit **Théodore de Régnon**, posits an East–West divide: "Latin philosophy envisages first the nature in itself and then proceeds to the expression; Greek philosophy envisages first the expression and then penetrates it to find the nature" — i.e. "Latin Trinitarianism, supremely represented by Augustine, started with the one God, and asked how he could be triune; by contrast Greek Trinitarianism began with the three hypostases."

De Régnon originally argued "for the necessity of both," but twentieth-century usage inverted it — "Augustine is held not to have understood the Cappadocian achievement" — producing "a caricatured distinction between Greek patristic 'personalism'... and Latin scholastic 'essentialism,'" and the charge that the Latin model harboured a "unitarian tendency."

Critique. The framework has been "severely, and rightly, criticized, as a gross and misleading oversimplification, especially when Augustine and Aquinas are included." **Barnes** argues Augustine has been "grossly misrepresented." **Ayres and Barnes** show "Augustine's concern in the book is largely polemical... at the heart of the polemic is an ongoing engagement with the Homoian tradition." **Holmes** declares "the falsity of what is called... the 'de Régnon thesis'"; recent scholarship holds that "the patristic inheritance, East and West, essentially spoke with one voice," built on the axioms that "the three persons work inseparably *ad extra*" and "the logic of the simplicity of God."

6. Twentieth-Century Systematics — Lonergan, Pannenberg, Gunton, Torrance

Bernard Lonergan (transcendental Thomist): his *Verbum* "overcame centuries of misinterpretation," and he praised Augustine's *De Trinitate* as "the high-water mark in Christian attempts to reach an understanding of the faith." "The heart of Lonergan's trinitarian theology lies in his dissection of Nicaea": "if the statements of Nicaea... are presented to us as *answers*, it is incumbent upon us... to come to know the *questions* which they are proposed to answer." His followers show the psychological analogy "can continue fruitfully to serve theology's endeavour to mediate the meaning of the trinitarian mystery."

Wolfhart Pannenberg reverses the dogmatic order, beginning with the threeness. The persons are "not 'different modes of being of the one divine subject,' but rather 'living realizations of separate centers of action.'" Using Hegelian self-distinction: "one gains one's personality by giving oneself to one's counterpart," yielding "dependent divinity" — even "the Father's fatherhood is dependent on the Son." Controversially: "Even in his deity... [God] has made himself dependent on the course of history"; divine unity is "realized in relation to the world" and "completed only eschatologically."

Colin Gunton: "Suddenly we are all trinitarians, or so it would seem." He "casts a sweeping indictment against Western thought," but Cunningham faults *The One, the Three and the Many* for a "Parmenidean... versus Heraclitean" scheme, a "surrender to the dichotomous 'either/or' mentality."

T. F. Torrance: on Athanasius identifying the *ousia* with the fountain of procession, "While this model might overcome the whole dispute regarding the *Filioque*... it also presents the great disadvantage of not being able to describe the specific office of the Father." (Alan Torrance separately faults Moltmann for "Pelagian tendencies" in his doxology.)

7. The Trinity, Christology, and the Economy of Salvation

The Church took over *oikonomia* to designate "God's saving plan and its implementation in salvation history." "The *oikonomia*, says Tertullian... develops the divine unity into a trinity." Aquinas ties the economic missions to the eternal processions: "The mission of the divine person is, so to say, an outflowing in time of his eternal procession."

Incarnation. Rahner grounds the identity axiom in the Incarnation: "Jesus is not simply God in general, but the Son... there is at least one 'mission'... which is not merely appropriated to some divine person, but which is proper to him." **Weinandy:** "The drama of the cross... mirrors the life within the Trinity. The Father eternally begets his Son in the Spirit of love... On earth, as man, in the Spirit of love, the Son, by his filial obedience to the Father, offered his human life." **Jüngel:** "The crucified Christ is... nothing less than a trace or vestige of the Trinity (*vestigium Trinitatis*)."
Von Balthasar: "Jesus is the person who so completely accepts, lives out, and identifies himself with his mission that whereas others may have a mission, he simply *is* his mission."

Reintegration. LaCugna warns the *theologia/oikonomia* split gave "a one-sided theology that had little to do with the economy of Christ and the Spirit." Rahner's axiom repairs it: "The 'economic' Trinity is the 'immanent' Trinity and the 'immanent' Trinity is the 'economic' Trinity." Moltmann pushes to eschatology: "The economic Trinity completes and perfects itself to immanent Trinity when the history and experience of salvation are completed and perfected."

8. The Trinity in Worship, Prayer, Mysticism, and Iconography

Liturgy as source of faith. "*Lex orandi, lex credendi.*" **Basil:** "As we are baptized, so, also, do we believe; as we believe, so, also, do we give glory."

Baptism. Moltmann: "The doctrine of the Trinity has baptism as its original *Sitz im Leben*."

Gregory of Nazianzus: "If He [the Holy Spirit] is not to be worshipped, how can He deify me by Baptism?" **Cyril of Jerusalem:** "At the same moment you both died and were born; that saving water became your tomb but also your mother."

Eucharist and doxology. The liturgy proceeds "giving thanks to the Father, remembering the saving deeds of the Son, and calling on the Spirit." Basil defended two doxological patterns — the **mediatorial** (Father *through* the Son *in* the Spirit, reflecting the economy) and the **co-**

ordinate (Father *with* the Son *and* the Spirit — the *Gloria Patri* — reflecting the immanent Trinity, "equal in majesty, undivided in splendour").

Prayer and mysticism. St Patrick's Breastplate: "I arise today / Through... the invocation of the Trinity, / Through the belief in the threeness, / Through the confession of the oneness." **John of the Cross:** "the soul united and transformed in God breathes out in God to God the very divine spiration." **Catherine of Siena** altered the *Gloria*: "Glory be to the Father and to Thee and to the Holy Ghost." **Elizabeth of the Trinity** found her vocation in the indwelling of all three persons in her soul.

Iconography. Early art obeyed "Christomorphism": "God could be painted, but only God made man." From the twelfth century five families emerged — the Throne of Grace, the Psalter Trinity, the Paternity, the Triandric Trinity, and the (later prohibited) Tricephalous Trinity. In the East, **Andrei Rublev's** fifteenth-century icon (from Gen 18) is the pinnacle, set as the standard by a 1928 Moscow synod. **Moltmann:** "Through their tenderly intimate inclination towards one another, the three Persons show the profound unity joining them... The chalice on the table points to the surrender of the Son on Golgotha... it is only in the unity with one another which springs from the self-giving of the Son 'for many' that men and women are in conformity with the triune God."

Part IV: Interreligious Frontiers and Global Contexts

Judaism and Islam, Russian sophiology, the Trinity as social programme, ecology and the sciences, divine simplicity, the renewal of pneumatology, and the global reception of the doctrine.

1. The Trinity and Judaism

Christian Trinitarianism emerged from within Jewish monotheism: "Both Christians and Jews join in the famous *Shema*... 'Hear, O Israel: The Lord our God, the Lord is one.'" What "became a full-fledged *trinitarian* confession... began... as a more-or-less binitarian understanding of God" — "explicit binitarianism and implicit trinitarianism."

Two powers / Philo. Philo of Alexandria posited that "in the one living and true God there were two supreme and primary powers, Goodness... and Authority... and that the third thing which was between the two... was the Logos"; "God and his two Powers are in reality one. To the human mind they appear as a Triad with God above the powers that belong to him."

Memra / Logos / Wisdom. In the LXX "the term *logos* (Hebrew *davar*) was used frequently to describe God's utterances," yet "Nowhere in the Old Testament is there any solid evidence that a sacred writer viewed the Word of Yahweh as a personal being distinct from Yahweh himself." Over time "Jewish thought had already bestowed a hypostatic character on such attributes as the name, the word, and the wisdom of God." "The prologue of the Fourth Gospel... seems to fuse the concept of Hebrew Logos with that of Wisdom."

Kabbalah, *zimsum*, *Shekinah*. Moltmann draws on Isaac Luria: "*Zimsum* really means 'concentration' or 'contraction', a withdrawal into the self." Applied to the Trinity: "a divine self-limitation occurs in the love between the Father and the Son through a 'contraction'... Eternity breathes itself in, so as to breathe out the Spirit of life." On the *Shekinah* (Rosenzweig): "God himself cuts himself off from himself, he gives himself away to his people, he suffers with their sufferings."

Jewish objections. *Dialogue with Trypho* — Trypho: "your assertion that this Christ existed as God before the ages... appears to me to be not merely paradoxical, but also foolish." The **Barcelona Disputation (1263)** — Nachmanides "agrees that God is wise, that he wills and is powerful, but insists that these are all attributes of the divine essence and that the doctrine of the Trinity is an erroneous conclusion." **Pinchas Lapide** (with Moltmann, 1978): Jews may read Trinitarianism "as either a heavenly triumvirate or, worse, as *tritheism*"; the incarnation earns the Talmudic term *shittuf*; he "chastises Christians for a want of shyness in their over-boldness to specify God... Trinitarianism inquires too deeply into 'the inscrutable God of the Bible.'"

2. The Trinity and Islam

Qur'anic critique. The Qur'an protests: "Indeed, the truth deny they who say: 'Behold, God is the third of a trinity' — seeing that there is no deity whatever save the One God." Against a Son:

"how could there be a 'son' to Him, there never having been a 'spouse' to Him"; "The heavens would almost break up... at it... they are claiming a son to the Merciful!"

Muslim objections — *tawhid* and *shirk*. For Muslims "God's oneness cannot be reconciled with the Trinity, which for them is nothing else than tritheism," making Christians "associators" guilty of *shirk* — "the only offence that God could never forgive: the denial of God's Uniqueness (*shirk*)." God's inner life is held inaccessible: "God's own internal life is unknown to man." And Islam "will never accept that its Christology is false."

Christian responses. John of Damascus (under Islamic rule) met the "associators" charge "by taking up the language of the Qur'an which speaks of the 'word and spirit' of God, and arguing that to deny the divinity of the word and spirit of God is to become a 'mutilator' of God," presenting the Trinity "starting from an uncompromising emphasis on the unity of God." **John Paul II:** Christians can explain "that the three Persons of the Godhead do not diminish divine unity but characterize it... The Christian doctrine of the Trinity explicitly rejects any form of tritheism or polytheism." **David Burrell:** the true parallel is not Jesus/Muhammad but Jesus/Qur'an — "Christians believe that Jesus is the Word of God made human, while Muslims believe the Qur'an to be the Word of God made 'book'" — and the Muslim doctrine of the *uncreated* Qur'an builds "a conceptual bridge to John 1:1."

3. Russian Sophiology — Soloviev, Florensky, Bulgakov

Vladimir Soloviev (1853–1900), "the father of Russian sophiology," gave the concept *bogochelovechestvo* ("God-manhood, the humanity of God, or divine-humanity") — signifying that "God's being as Trinitarian is always-already an eternal communion with humanity."

Pavel Florensky critiqued the Eastern neglect of the Spirit: "'Unnoticed and gradually' a tendency had permeated the Church to speak, rather than of the Holy Spirit, of 'grace', that is, of something already and conclusively impersonal," words that "only slightly if at all have in their sights the personal independent existence of the third hypostasis."

Sergius Bulgakov (1871–1944) systematized sophiology. "Sophia is the 'self-revelation of the Holy Trinity'; the Father is 'Divine Depth and Mystery, the Divine Subject of self-revelation,' revealed in the Son and completed by the Spirit — 'the hypostatic love that unites the Father and the Son.'" Crucially, "Sophia is not another *hypostasis*... nor some 'thing' in addition to the *ousia* and *hypostases* of the Trinity"; rather "Sophia is the *ousia* (nature) of God, but the *ousia* of God *as* revealed" — "Divine Sophia is God's exhaustive self-revelation, the fullness of divinity." Sophia "unites God with the world as the one common principle"; "One and the same Sophia is revealed in God and in creation" — the "cosmic *sobornost* of concrete all-unity in divine love." The "Sophia Affair" saw Lossky attack sophiology from a strictly apophatic, essence-energies standpoint.

4. The Trinity as Social Programme — Liberation and Political Theology

The nineteenth-century Orthodox thinker **Nicolai Fedorov** "coined the expression 'the Trinity is our social programme.'"

Leonardo Boff uses *perichoresis* to present God as an inclusive society, "a model for any just, egalitarian... social organization." Defective images distort society (Father-alone → authoritarianism; Spirit-alone → anarchism); the Triune God demands justice: "a society that takes its inspiration from trinitarian communion cannot tolerate class differences, dominations based on power." "By their practice and theory, capitalist regimes contradict the challenges and invitations of Trinitarian communion." "Human society is a pointer on the road to the mystery of the Trinity."

Jürgen Moltmann turns social Trinitarianism against "Christian monotheism," which "provides the justification for earthly domination... a 'holy rule.'" "This doctrine of the Trinity must be developed as the true theological doctrine of freedom" — corresponding to "a community of men and women, without privileges and without subjugation." "The Christian doctrine of the Trinity *compels* us to develop social personalism or personal socialism."

Black and Hispanic. James Cone: the blackness of God reveals "a 'beloved triune community' at work in the liberation of the oppressed." US Hispanic theology finds in the Trinity's threefold differentiation "a prophetic alternative" to assimilation.

Critiques. **Karen Kilby** warns of projecting "fashionable political concepts onto God." **Kathryn Tanner**: *perichoresis* yields "very vague recommendations." **Miroslav Volf** ("*The Trinity Is Our Social Program?*"): "the road from the doctrine of the Trinity to proposals about global or national social arrangements is long, torturous, and fraught with danger" — Novak and Boff draw opposite (capitalist vs socialist) conclusions from the same doctrine; Trinitarian concepts apply to human community "only in an analogous rather than a univocal sense."

5. Ecological Trinitarian Theology, Panentheism, and the Sciences

Ecology. Moltmann: "I was able to write an ecological doctrine of creation... because I could replace thinking in the language of domination... by a thinking in networks and milieus," recovering "the biblical perspective on nature as the household (*oikos*)... the permanent dwelling place of God." **Ivone Gebara** (ecofeminist): though the Trinity may seem "superfluous... in the light of the anguished cries of so many," she finds its "'trinitarian structure' of oneness as diversity permeates the cosmos."

Panentheism. Moltmann advances a "trinitarian panentheism": "God, having created the world, also dwells in it, and conversely the world which he has created exists in him," consummated when "God in the world and the world in God... the glorifying of the world through the Spirit." **Pannenberg** objects: "the equation of the two means the absorption of the immanent Trinity in the economic Trinity."

The Spirit in creation. **Luther** on Gen 1:2: "the Holy Spirit broods. As a hen broods her eggs... it is the office of the Holy Spirit to make alive." **Maximus the Confessor**: "The Holy Spirit is not absent from any created being... providentially permeating all things with His power." **Aquinas**: the Spirit is the "'Life-Giver'... who 'guides and quickens all things created by the Father through the Son.'"

Sciences. "Some leading science and theology scholars have... recently shown growing interest in the intersection of the Trinity and... our cosmos." Moltmann integrates evolution: the Spirit as "the principle of creativity," "principle of individuation," and "holistic principle." **Richard Swinburne** (Bayesian): "if there is a God, who is a person, the doctrine of the Trinity is what we should expect." **Paul Davies** treats the laws as a Platonic ground but rejects biblical Trinitarianism.

6. The Trinity, Divine Simplicity, and Classical Theism

Simplicity. God "is what God is said to 'have.'"
Augustine: "Our reason for calling the Trinity simple is because it is what it has — with the exception of the real relations in which the Persons stand to each other."
Gregory of Nyssa rejected Eunomius's equation of simplicity with "ungeneracy."
Aquinas: "the divine simplicity requires in God that essence be identical with *suppositum*... in God essence is not really distinct from person; and yet the persons are really distinguished from one another. For 'person'... signifies relation as subsisting in the divine nature."

Attributes. "God is substance as he is wisdom or is wisdom as he is substance." **Richard of St Victor**: "everything that is found within... true divinity is really, substantially and supremely one." Appropriations then assign the common attributes — power to the Father, wisdom to the Son, goodness to the Spirit.

Aseity and innascibility. **Barth**: "The eternal Trinity is distinguished... by the simplicity, perfection and a-seity... of its essence."
Bonaventure roots the Father in *fontalis plenitudo* and innascibility — "the Father can be conceived of as a person in virtue of his primacy alone."

Aquinas counters: "Innascibility is a pure negation... we must presuppose some prior, positive understanding of the Father as a principle, and this prior understanding is given in the notion of paternity."

Classical theism. "God is absolutely Simple: he is Act, without composition, without movement, and without becoming... God is beyond all change." Hegel turned substance into subject ("one subject — three modes of being"); Moltmann critiques the "monotheistic God... defined simply through his power of disposal," against which "the triune God represents an inexhaustible life... in which they are present with one another, for one another and in one another."

7. The Twentieth-Century Renewal of Pneumatology — Congar and Others

Yves Congar (*I Believe in the Holy Spirit*) repaired the Christology–pneumatology split: "there can be no Christology without pneumatology and no pneumatology without Christology,"

developing a "pneumatological Christology," and recovering the early charismatic life (the apostles "set out, filled with the assurance of the Holy Spirit").

Bulgakov: "The Holy Spirit is the hypostatic love that unites the Father and the Son"; the Son is Truth, the Spirit is Beauty; as "spirit of truth" the Spirit "represents the principle of reality."

Moltmann: a reciprocal "pneumatological christology" and "christological doctrine of the Spirit." "Through the powers and potentialities of the Spirit, the Creator indwells the creatures he has made." The Spirit is an active subject: "The Spirit is the glorifying God. The Spirit is the unifying God... a subject from whose activity the Son and the Father receive their glory and their union."

John Paul II (*Dominum et Vivificantem*, 1986): the Spirit acted "even before Christ — from the beginning"; "every quest of the human spirit for truth and goodness, and in the last analysis for God, is inspired by the Holy Spirit" — grounding a pneumatological theology of religions.

8. Global and Non-Western Trinitarian Theologies

Christianity is now "a predominantly non-Western religion"; "as the Church inculturates globally, there will be other ways of speaking the truth of God's Trinity... that will deepen the understanding of God's mystery." **Miguel Díaz:** "God is not only Greek or Latin, but must also be black, red, Asian, Latin American, and US Hispanic."

East Asia — Yin-Yang. **Jung Young Lee** proposes a Trinity of change: "God the Father as 'change itself,' God the Holy Spirit as 'the power of change,' and God the Son as 'the perfect manifestation of change.'" Christ "can be understood as the *Tao* (Way)"; the Spirit as feminine "Mother (Yin)" and *ch'i*, "the vital energy... very much similar to... *ruach* in Hebrew and *pneuma* in Greek." **Heup Young Kim** sees a "decentering [of] Western theology."

India — *Saccidananda*. Christian encounter first fixed on the *Trimurti* (Brahma, Vishnu, Shiva), but the deeper inculturation came through *Saccidananda* (*sat, cit, ananda*). **Keshab Chunder Sen** correlated Father, Son, Spirit with *sat, cit, ananda* — "the True, the Good, the Beautiful." **Monchanin and Abhishiktananda** (Henri Le Saux) at their *Saccidananda Ashram* prayed to the Father as *sat* (the "principleless Principle"), the Son as *cit* (the "intellectual Image of the Existent"), the Spirit as *ananda*; **Brahmabandhab Upadhyay** drew on Thomism (hymn *Vande Saccidanandam*) to refine Sen's analogy with proper senses of "person" and "nature."

Buddhism — *Trikāya*. **James Fredericks** finds a parallel in the Mahayana "three bodies of the Buddha" — the formless *Dharmakāya* using "skillful means" (*Sambhogakāya, Nirmānakāya*) out of compassion — a relational ontology helping Christians imagine God "not as a static 'substance,' but as a dynamic, self-emptying movement of love."

Africa. Theologians build "employing distinctively African resources, including... the ancestry theme." **Mercy Amba Oduyoye** relates the Trinity "to traditional African life and conceptions of community": "Our baptism into the name of the Trinity means that we should stand not for monarchies and hierarchies but rather for participation."

Limits. Inculturation must "test [its] continuity with the Church's Graeco-Latin heritage so that philosophy and culture do not dictate to revelation." "The concept of person does not translate easily into Sanskrit"; cross-cultural Trinitarian mapping "will always fall short of the exactitude that would make it entirely compelling" — yet remains "a necessary and deeply enriching evolution of the doctrine in the third millennium."

End of the consolidated edition. All texts and quotations retrieved verbatim from the notebook's sources with their internal citations preserved. Four parts, thirty-two sections, spanning Scripture, every historical era, the disputed systematic questions, worship, the interreligious frontiers, and the global reception of the doctrine of the Trinity.